

— PARTNER BRIEFING

South Africa's HR and Payroll Opportunity

Where NovaHR fits in the market, who we compete with, and how we win.

Most SA Businesses Are Running on **Spreadsheets**

And it is costing them time, money, and compliance risk.



Payroll done manually in Excel every month

One mistake means SARS penalties or staff paid wrongly



Leave tracked on paper or WhatsApp

No visibility, no records, disputes at year end



Employee documents in filing cabinets

Hard to find, easy to lose, impossible to audit



SARS and Department of Labour reports done by hand

EMP201, IRP5, UIF declarations — monthly stress



No visibility for managers and executives

HR knows what is happening; no one else does



Paying an accountant or bureau for basic payroll

Expensive, slow, and you still do not own the data

A Large and Underserved Market

South Africa's SME sector is the largest single employer in the country.

3.2M+

Small and medium businesses registered in South Africa

67%

Of SA private-sector employment is in SMEs

10–100

Employees: our primary target, the most underserved band

R499

Per month starting price, less than most payroll bureaux charge

Who We Target First

A growing South African company with 10 to 100 staff. One person handling HR and payroll. Currently on Excel, an accountant, or basic payroll software. They need leave management, accurate payslips, and to stay on the right side of SARS, without hiring a specialist or paying enterprise software prices.

Why Now?

- SARS enforcement of ETI, EMP501 and IRP5 is increasing
- BCEA and POPIA compliance requirements are growing
- Post-COVID, businesses want to reduce reliance on external bureaux
- Cloud software is now affordable and trusted for sensitive data
- Competing tools are either too simple or too expensive for this segment

One Workspace to Run **Your Entire Team**

Not a payroll calculator. Not a standalone HR tool. Everything in one place.



Employee Management

Digital profiles, documents, banking details, contracts. Everything in one place, properly organised.



Leave Management

Annual, sick, family responsibility, maternity and more. Employees apply, managers approve, HR tracks. All BCEA compliant.



Payroll and Payslips

SARS-compliant payroll every month. PAYE, UIF, SDL, ETI, garnishees. Branded payslips emailed to staff. Pay via Netcash.



SARS Compliance

EMP201, EMP501, IRP5 and IT3(a) certificates. Employment Equity reports. UIF declarations. All from the same payroll data.

Simple for Everyone on the Team

Different views for different people, all from the same platform.

HR Administrator

- Add and manage all employees
- Process payroll each month
- Approve or decline leave requests
- Generate SARS reports
- Store and manage documents
- Track compliance deadlines

Who this is for
The person who runs HR and payroll

Employees

- View and download their payslips
- Apply for leave online
- Check leave balances
- Update their own details
- View their documents

Who this is for
Every person in the business

Managers and Directors

- Approve team leave requests
- View team headcount and salary overview
- See payroll spend by department
- Employment equity snapshot
- No access to what they should not see

Who this is for
Team leads, executives, business owners

Who Else Is in the Market

There are competitors, but none own the full SME payroll-plus-HR workflow at NovaHR's price point.

WHO WE COMPETE WITH DIRECTLY

SP

SimplePay
Online payroll only, per employee pricing

Payroll only

SG

Sage Business Cloud Payroll
Large installed base, accountant-friendly, fragmented

Legacy stack

PD

PayDay
Traditional payroll and HR, municipalities and large clients

Conservative buyers

HS

HRSimplified
HR-first, per employee, payroll via integration

HR only

WHO WE ARE NOT FIGHTING

DL

Deel Local Payroll (ex-PaySpace)
Enterprise payroll, multi-country, complex companies

Partner / refer up

SH

SeamlessHR
Full African HR suite, 100+ employee companies

Different segment

WD

Workday / SAP
Enterprise, expensive, complex to implement

Enterprise only

The real competition
The biggest competitor is Excel and an accountant. Those are the customers we are converting.

Why Businesses Choose NovaHR

Against direct competitors, these are the differences that matter.



Payroll and HR in One Place

Most competitors are either payroll-only or HR-only. NovaHR does both in a single system, so there is no double data entry and no risk of payroll and leave records being out of sync.



South African Compliance Built In

Not bolted on. PAYE, UIF, SDL, ETI, EMP201, EMP501, IRP5 and Employment Equity are built into the payroll engine. When SARS changes the rules, so does NovaHR.



Pay Via Netcash Directly

NovaHR connects directly to Netcash for bulk salary payments. No need to download a file and upload it somewhere else — the payment flows from payroll approval.



Simple Flat Pricing

One monthly price for all features. No per-employee charges that surprise you as you grow. At 30 employees, NovaHR Growth works out to about R33 per person per month, including payroll.



Modern Design, Easy to Use

Built for business owners and their teams, not payroll professionals. Clean interface, branded payslips, dark mode, and role-based views so each person sees only what they need.



Faster Than a Bureau

Log in, run payroll, approve it, pay staff. No waiting for a third party. The business owner or HR admin is in full control, with a complete audit trail.

What We Are Building Next

We are honest about where we are. Here is the roadmap to make NovaHR impossible to beat in our segment.

NOW (0 TO 30 DAYS)	Become the Safest Choice Two-factor login security (MFA). Annual tax table verification by a registered tax practitioner. A formal migration kit so businesses can move from SimplePay, Sage or Excel safely. Written answers to every security question a buyer might have.
SOON (30 TO 60 DAYS)	Make the Accountant a Partner A proper accounting journal export (gross pay, net pay, PAYE, UIF, SDL by department) that an accountant can import directly into Xero or Sage Accounting. Once this is done, accountants recommend NovaHR to their clients instead of competing with it.
SOON (30 TO 60 DAYS)	Mobile for Every Employee A mobile-friendly version employees can install on their phones (PWA). View payslips, apply for leave, check leave balance. Most employees are on their phones, not a desktop.
NEXT (60 TO 90 DAYS)	Compliance Calendar and Timesheet Input A dashboard that shows every compliance deadline with a green/amber/red status. Plus the ability to import timesheets for hourly staff so that overtime is calculated automatically in payroll.

Simple, Predictable Flat-Rate Pricing

One monthly price. All features included. No per-employee surprises.

STARTER

R499

per month

Up to 10 employees

Employee management

Leave management

Full payroll and payslips

SARS compliance reports

Email support

MOST POPULAR

GROWTH

R999

per month

Up to 30 employees

Everything in Starter

Multi-department structure

Advanced payroll reports

Advanced leave reports

Priority support

SCALE

R2,499

per month

Unlimited employees

Everything in Growth

Dedicated onboarding

API access

Custom integrations

Advanced reporting

All prices exclude VAT. No setup fees. No long-term contract. Cancel any time.

The Category We Own: SA Compliance-First HR for SMEs

We are not trying to be everything to everyone. We are the best tool for this specific job.

Our Category Statement

"NovaHR is the South African HR and payroll workspace for growing teams. Run compliant payroll, manage leave and employee records, pay staff, and stay on top of SARS and people obligations from one place."

The Businesses We Are Perfect For

- 10 to 100 employees, single South African entity
- One HR or office administrator handling people and payroll
- Currently on Excel, an accountant, or basic payroll software
- Professional services, agencies, retail head offices, clinics, hospitality groups
- Want to run payroll themselves and see compliance clearly

What Makes Businesses Switch to NovaHR

- Payroll mistakes or SARS penalties from Excel errors
- Leave disputes because no records existed
- Accountant bills going up for basic payroll processing
- Business growing past what spreadsheets can handle
- New HR hire who wants a proper system, not a folder

What We Do Not Try to Do (Yet)

- Multi-country payroll or global employment (Deel does this)
- Complex bargaining council payroll or 250+ employee enterprise
- Fully outsourced payroll service
- Applicant tracking, learning management or performance reviews

Built, Verified, and Live on the Internet

NovaHR is a real product with real functionality, not a concept.

301

Automated tests passing (payroll calculation, tax logic, compliance)

LIVE

novahr-five.vercel.app — production verified 11 July 2026

9

BCEA leave types implemented and tested in payroll engine

4

Branded payslip templates with logo, colour, and layout choices

What Is Already Working

- Full payroll: PAYE, UIF, SDL, ETI, garnishees, loans, unpaid leave
- EMP201, EMP501, IRP5/IT3(a) and EEA2/EEA4 reports
- Netcash direct payment submission
- Leave management with 9 leave types and calendar view
- Employee document vault (private, access-controlled storage)
- POPIA data export and erasure tools
- Role-based access: HR, Manager, Employee, Executive
- 5 golden-path end-to-end tests passing in automated suite

What Is Coming Next

- Two-factor login (MFA)
- Accounting journal export for Xero/Sage
- Mobile-installable employee app (PWA)
- Compliance deadline calendar with evidence tracking
- Timesheet import for hourly workers and overtime
- Accountant partner portal
- PayFast subscription billing (pending business bank account)
- Resend email service (pending custom domain)

WHAT WE NEED FROM YOU

Let's Build This Together

1 Design Partner Introductions

Two to three businesses who will trial NovaHR in parallel with their current payroll, give honest feedback, and report any issues before the public launch.

2 Accountant and Bookkeeper Connections

Accountants who can test the journal export and validate that it fits their reconciliation workflow. Their endorsement is the most powerful sales tool in the SME market.

3 Feedback on Priorities

Tell us what would make NovaHR impossible to ignore for the businesses you know. What is the one thing they ask for that they cannot get from SimplePay or Sage?

novahr-five.vercel.app Live platform — request a walkthrough